

consider your diet and exercise as simple energy deficits and excesses, with a straight calorie-in, calorie-burned equation, you will fall into the trap of misspecifying the system into simple causal and mechanical links. Your food intake becomes the equivalent of filling up the tank of your new BMW. If, on the other hand, you look at food and exercise as activating metabolic signals, with potential metabolic cascades and nonlinearities from network effects, and with recursive links, then welcome to complexity, hence Extremistan. Both food and workouts provide your body with information about stressors in the environment. As I have been saying throughout, informational randomness is from Extremistan. Medicine fell into the trap of using simple thermodynamics, with the same physics envy, and the same mentality, and the same tools as economists did when they looked at the economy as a web of simple links.* And both humans and societies are complex systems.

But these lifestyle ideas do not come from mere self-experimentation or some quack theory. All the results were completely expected from the evidence-based, peer-reviewed research that is available. Hunger (or episodic energy deficit) strengthens the body and the immune system and helps rejuvenate brain cells, weaken cancer cells, and prevent diabetes. It was just that the current thinking—in a way similar to economics—was out of sync with the empirical research. I was able to re-create 90 percent of the benefits of the hunter-gatherer lifestyle with minimal effort, without compromising a modern lifestyle, in the aesthetics of an urban setting (I get extremely bored in nature and prefer walking around the Jewish quarter of Venice to spending time in Bora Bora).*

By the same argument we can lower 90 percent of Black Swan risks in economic life ... by just eliminating speculative debt.

The only thing currently missing from my life is panic, from, say, finding a gigantic snake in my library, or watching the economist Myron Scholes, armed to the teeth, walk into my bedroom in the middle of the night. I lack what the biologist Robert Sapolsky calls the beneficial aspect of acute stress, compared to the deleterious one of dull stress—another barbell, for no stress plus a little bit of extreme stress is vastly better than a little bit of stress (like mortgage worries) all the time.

Some have argued that my health benefits come from long walks, about ten to fifteen hours a week (though nobody has explained to me why they would count as workouts since I walk slowly), while others claim that they come from my few minutes of sprinting; I've had the same problem explaining the inseparability of the two extremes as I did